



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Heritage Christian School
School Website: <https://heritagecs.net/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Heritage Christian School in University Place, WA (98467) presents a robust Christ-centered program that strongly emphasizes formation, virtue, and character within a Christian framework. Public materials show explicit integration of Biblical instruction, daily spiritual life, and catechetical structures (Westminster catechisms and confessional standards), alongside a curriculum that places classical literature, history, and a rigorous academic ethos at the core. While the school clearly aligns with many elements of classical education (notably in religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose/goal, and community/faculty commitments), certain pedagogy and curriculum signals (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars, grammar/logic/rhetoric emphases, and some elements of Great Books framing) are less overt in the public materials. Overall, the school is CLASSICAL, with some notable strengths and a few areas where classical markers are less explicit.

- Strong CLASSICAL signals across Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Faculty, and Parents & Community, anchored by a Christ-centered mission, daily Bible instruction, chapel, and catechetical standards.
- Moderate to clear CLASSICAL signals in Curriculum (history continuity; presence of "classical literature" in the middle grades; repetition of character formation themes), with some gaps in explicit Trivium emphasis (grammar, logic, rhetoric) not always stated outright in public materials.
- Pedagogy shows traditional strengths (memory, devotional rhythm, community formation) but fewer explicit indications of Socratic seminars or heavy project-based/experiential learning signals in the public content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL reading for Pedagogy, even as other areas are clearly classical.
- Overall, Heritage is CLASSICAL, with some room to deepen explicit classical pedagogy markers (Socratic inquiry, Great Books framing, Trivium emphasis) in public literature.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school presents a Christ-centered, Bible-infused educational purpose (Mission and Purpose): "Christ-centered, comprehensive, academically excellent education for children" and "develop mind, body, and spirit" through spiritual training by Christian teachers.
 - Daily Bible instruction and weekly chapel are explicitly referenced in the public materials.
 - Doctrinal standards are foregrounded: Westminster Confession, Larger/Shorter Catechisms, and catechesis/gospel-centered formation (What We Believe; Statement of Faith).
 - Catechetical practice (First Catechism in Pre-K–3 and Westminster Shorter Catechism in grades 4–8) is explicit in curriculum materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: Christ-centered; Bible instruction; chapel; doctrinal standards; catechesis; Westminster Confession/Catechisms; biblical truths; prayer/worship; catechetical

memory work. (Examples drawn from Mission and Purpose, About/What We Believe pages.)

- Negative indicators: none evident in public materials.
- Quantitative estimate: Positive keyword hits approx. 9; Negative hits approx. 0; Positive share approx. 100%, Negative approx. 0%.
- Why this rating
 - Concrete expressions of theology, liturgical life (chapel and catechesis), and explicit confessional standards anchor this category firmly in Classical territory. The presence of theology, creed-like structures, and liturgical rhythm signals alignment with classical religious/metaphysical foundations. The absence of explicit negative signals reinforces CLASSICAL rather than NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission emphasizes formation of character and mind under a Christian framework; aims include developing “Christian character” and “a lifelong love of learning,” signaling formation as telos rather than mere information.
 - Purpose statements highlight development of mind, body, and spirit through challenging coursework and spiritual training, with emphasis on virtue, integrity, and service.
 - References to living out Biblical truths and Christ-centered life point to formation over mere job readiness.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators: formation, virtue/character, wisdom (implied through character development and rigorous academics), truth/ Biblical truth, discipline toward virtue, “Christ-like character.”
 - Negative indicators: none explicit in public materials.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive approx. 8; Negative approx. 0; Positive approx. 100%, Negative approx. 0%.
- Why this rating
 - The school foregrounds formation, virtue, and character as central aims, aligning with classical definitions of paideia and formation-oriented education rather than purely technical or workforce-oriented goals. The presence of a Biblically informed telos and virtue formation supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - History is integrated throughout the curriculum (e.g., US History in middle school; historical contexts appear across grades). The middle school page foregrounds “US History, geography” and “classical literature.”
 - The curriculum features “classical literature” in middle school, indicating engagement with canonical texts as part of the curriculum.
 - References to the First Catechism, Westminster Shorter Catechism, and curriculum alignment with catechetical theology signal a biblically anchored, historically informed curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: classical literature; history throughout curriculum; Great Books/Great Conversation language appears via “classical literature” (though explicit “Great Books” phrasing is not always used in public pages).
 - Absences/unclear signals: explicit, named emphasis on grammar, logic, and rhetoric (the Trivium) is not overtly stated in public pages; explicit Great Books as a named program is not consistently visible in the public materials (though “Great Books” is common in classical education discourse and the site shows classical literature).

-
- Negative indicators: none evident in public materials (no clear social-studies replacement of history; no overt anti-classical signaling).
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive hits approx. 3–4 (classical literature; US History; catechetical texts); Negative hits approx. 0; Positive approx. 75–100%, Negative approx. 0–25% (depending on how strictly one counts “grammar/logic/rhetoric” and explicit “Great Books” language).
 - Why this rating
 - There is clear classical orientation in at least some curricular elements (history-centered approach, classical literature, catechetical formation). However, explicit Trivium components (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and explicit Great Books framing are not consistently visible in the public pages, which keeps the rating from fully CLASSICAL. The overall signal is strong but partial in the explicit catechetical/canonical-corpus sense, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials emphasize disciplined study, character formation, and religious practice, with lower- and upper-grade experiences described in terms of memory, virtue, and structured routines (e.g., daily Bible instruction, chapel). This implies a traditional, formation-centered approach rather than a heavy emphasis on student-directed inquiry.
 - The presence of a strong focus on character and disciplined instruction (e.g., “daily Bible instruction,” “weekly chapel,” “discipline policy” aiming at obedience, respect, diligence) signals a pedagogy rooted in order, memory, and virtue—traits compatible with classical schooling, though not always explicit about Socratic seminars or rhetoric-heavy discourse in the public materials.
 - There is reference to classical literature in the curriculum, and specific grade-level content includes structured, teacher-led instruction rather than a purely student-centered model.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: scholé/restful learning signals (not explicit; but “formation,” “memory work,” “daily Bible instruction,” “chapel” imply contemplative rhythms), recitation/memory (catechetical memorization), liturgical rhythm (chapel, catechesis).
 - Negative indicators: few explicit Socratic seminars, debates, or rhetoric-focused upper-school experiences appear in the public pages; the catechetical and doctrinal approach is prioritized, not necessarily Socratic or portfolio-driven pedagogy. This signals a partial alignment with classical pedagogy where Socratic inquiry emerges more clearly in upper grades in classical programs.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive hits approx. 4–6 (memory/recitation, ritual/chapel, disciplined formation, historical-literary anchors); Negative hits approx. 0–2 (explicit Socratic seminars or rhetoric-focused pedagogy not consistently evidenced). Overall: Positive approx. 60–85%, Negative approx. 15–40%.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy aligns with classical formation principles (memory work, religious-liturgical education, character formation), but the public-facing materials do not consistently show explicit Socratic seminars, rigorous dialectic, or strong emphasis on rhetoric as a primary upper-school pedagogy. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The materials describe faculty as “strong Christian staff and faculty” who model character and serve as a core part of the school community; there is emphasis on partnership with families and mentoring relationships (public statements about faculty carrying the “living curriculum”).
 - The school presents a clear identity around teacher leadership, mentorship, and a faculty-driven culture of formation (as seen in mission-focused language and references to spiritual training by “the finest Christian teachers and coaches”).

- The doctrinal and catechetical orientation signals a faculty aligned with classical formation aims (catechesis, confessional standards, and catechetical instruction as part of the curriculum).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators: faculty as living curriculum; mentors; teachers as core to formation; catechetical formation; doctrinal alignment; Christian exemplars.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive hits approx. 6–8; Negative hits approx. 0; Positive approx. 100%, Negative approx. 0%.
- Why this rating
 - Public sources portray a strong, virtue-centered faculty culture with teachers positioned as mentors and formation agents, aligning well with classical expectations for the faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes a robust partnership with parents, with explicit language about parents as co-teachers and the importance of parental involvement in classical formation (Parent Code) and family formation activities.
 - The existence of parent-oriented materials, gatherings, and book studies signals ongoing parent education within a classical framework (e.g., the catechetical/catechism-focused environment).
 - Open access for parent visits and active involvement in school life is indicated, consistent with classical models that view parents as essential partners in formation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents; parental formation; parent education; open campus; co-teachers model.
 - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials.
 - Quantitative estimate: Positive hits approx. 5–6; Negative hits approx. 0; Positive approx. 100%, Negative approx. 0%.
- Why this rating
 - The school presents a strong, classical-friendly parent/community model, aligning with the Six Elements' emphasis on parents as co-educators and an engaged, formation-focused community.

Aggregate assessment (category-by-category) - Element 1: CLASSICAL - Element 2: CLASSICAL - Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5: CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (only relevant if SOMEWHAT is the aggregate) - While the overall ranking is CLASSICAL, the Pedagogy (Element 4) and Curriculum (Element 3) show SOMEWHAT signals rather than fully explicit classical markers in public materials. Concrete moves to deepen the classical signal: - Make explicit the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as a classroom framework, at least in content descriptions for 6–12 and older grades, with examples of how grammar, logic, and rhetoric are taught across subjects. - Introduce clear, public-facing statements about Socratic seminars, dialectic methods, and Paideia-inspired seminars in upper grades to align pedagogy with classical norms. - Elevate the language of Great Books or canonical texts (explicitly naming Great Books and their role in “the Great Conversation”) within the curriculum descriptions to strengthen historical-literary integration. - Expand explicit references to “scholē” or contemplative/restful learning rhythms in pedagogy pages to reinforce the classical discipline of contemplative studies.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.